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Two Arrested on Suspicion of Setting Fires in Sepulveda Basin

November 1, 2025 | Santa Monica Mirror (CA)
Author: SM.a.r.t | Section: Hard | 343 Words
OpenURL Link

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Two people have been arrested on suspicion of setting fires in the Sepulveda Basin and the San Fernando Valley, Mayor Karen Bass announced Friday.

The arrests were made by Los Angeles Park Rangers from the Department of Recreation and Parks in coordination with the Los Angeles Fire Department's Arson Investigation Unit.

Bass said the arrests are part of a broader city effort to improve safety and cleanliness in the 2,000-acre Sepulveda Basin Recreation Area. The initiative, launched in July and led by Bass and Councilmember Imelda Padilla, combines law enforcement, fire prevention and homeless outreach.

"We have been executing a coordinated and comprehensive strategy in partnership with Councilmember Imelda Padilla in the Sepulveda Basin that is first and foremost about public safety," Bass said in a statement. "From holding people accountable who commit crimes of arson to outreaching to people experiencing homelessness, we are using every available tool to make the Sepulveda Basin recreation area and surrounding neighborhoods safer and cleaner for all."

Padilla said the effort involves cooperation across multiple city departments, including Public Works and the Fire Department. "This unprecedented intergovernmental effort is setting the foundation to restore the Basin's safety, environmental health, and accessibility for all our residents," she said.

According to LAFD, fire-related calls in the Sepulveda Basin have significantly decreased since the city began its coordinated efforts.

The city's ongoing strategy includes homeless outreach, vegetation management to reduce fire risk, and debris removal. Firefighters have cleared hundreds of trees and about 240 tons of debris near the Hjelte Sports Complex, while heavy equipment crews continue clearing brush along Woodley Avenue and the 405 Freeway.

State funding secured through Padilla, Sen. Henry Stern, and Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel — and approved by Gov. Gavin Newsom — will support further safety and cleanliness improvements in the area.

Bass said she continues to meet with community members and city agencies to ensure the plan addresses local needs effectively. The project is being coordinated with nonprofit partners and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, which oversees much of the basin land.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  SM.a.r.t. (2025, November 1). Two Arrested on Suspicion of Setting Fires in Sepulveda Basin.*Santa Monica Mirror (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A41C5ECD10010E8.